



insight ■ tips and tricks

WEB GRAPHICS

Smart ways to get sharp, yet small images for use on the Web

■ Reducing file size for Web images

To save images for the Web, preferably save them as transparent images so that they take up less space. Go to the Layers palette and simply delete the Background layer. This leaves only transparent layers above it. Now when you click on Save for web, the checkbox for Transparency is no longer grayed out.

■ Clean Type for the Web

For use on the Web, a type size below 12 points becomes blurry. To maintain the visibility, do not reduce the type size further. Instead, increase the positive tracking and try to keep the tracking anywhere between 20 to 50 points. This will not only keep the size small, but will also maintain the visibility of the type.

■ Trim for the Web

Another way to keep file sizes small is to use the Trim function from the Image menu. It will crop your Web graphic as tightly as possible for the smallest possible file size. It does this by looking at the pixel colour in the upper left hand corner of your image and it keeps cropping down until it hits another colour.

■ Layer-based slices

Photoshop can automatically flatten your image for the

Web and slice it too by using layer-based slices. If you create a layer-based slice, when you move the layer, Photoshop will automatically adjust all the slices to accommodate your move and it will also create a new slice layer for your layer. From the Layer menu, choose New Layer Based Slice in case of changes in the layer. Also, if you let Photoshop do the slicing, you don't have to drag out slices—Photoshop does the slicing exactly at the size of your layer.

The new Slice options in Photoshop 7 allow you to link and unlink your slices. Linking the slices allows them to share the same colour palette and dithering options, which prevents visible seams that occur between the lines due to changes.

■ Get rid of those annoying marching ants

There are times when the selected portion in an image shows annoying lines called selection border, popularly known as 'marching ants'. If



The selection still remains even after removing the selection border



Portable Network Graphics (PNG)

PNG was originally designed to replace the popular Gif format. It supports 24 and 48 bit images, while gif supports only 8 bit. PNG also supports RGB, Grayscale and Indexed colour image modes as well as varying levels of transparency, for example, soft drop shadows, which are not supported by GIF and JPEG. The downside is that in PNG files, the colour images are often larger than in GIF or JPEG images because

they contain more colours and don't compress like JPEG. The biggest disadvantage is that they are not supported entirely by the browser world. Though they are natively supported by Microsoft Internet Explorer and Netscape Navigator, the 32-bit RGB transparency is supported by Windows Internet Explorer. So they are ideally suited only for small images such as buttons and thumbnails with details.

the selection border gets annoying, press [Ctrl] + [H]. By doing this, your selection remains but the marching ants disappear. This command is known as 'Show Extras'.

■ Using the WBMP format

Photoshop 7 supports a new file format called WBMP. This is designed specifically

for mobile devices such as cell phones and PDAs. The format supports only 1 colour, that is, either pixel is black or white. It can use masks from Type layers, Shape layers and alpha channels to vary the density percentage across an image. This technique produces higher-quality results in small image areas without increasing file size.

FILTERS

Filters can give you some amazing effects, provided you know how to use them correctly.

■ Straighten those jagged Lasso tool selections

Can a Lasso tool give a smooth selection? Draw the area you want to use as your selection and press [q] to enter Quick Mask mode (your selection will now be surrounded by solid pink). From the Filter menu, under Noise, choose Median. As



Getting smooth selection edge

you raise the radius of the Median filter, the edge smoothen out. When you find it satisfactory, press